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一、文章主旨

英文主旨

This article discusses how the American middle-class family, which once relied on hard work and fair play for financial security, has been transformed by economic risks. It analyzes three main sources of increased family risk: the disappearance of the backup earner as more women entered the workforce, greater risks in retirement income due to changes in Social Security and investment-based plans, and rising healthcare costs and demographic challenges. The author concludes that this shift of financial risk onto overburdened middle-class families will have both financial and political consequences.

中文主旨

本文探讨了曾经依靠辛勤工作和公平竞争就能维持经济稳定的美国中产阶级家庭，如何被经济风险和新的现实所改变。文章分析了家庭风险上升的三个主要来源：随着更多女性进入职场，家庭失去了备用收入来源；社会保障改革和投资型计划导致退休收入风险增加；医疗成本上升以及人口结构变化带来的负担。作者最后指出，这种将金融风险大规模转移到本已不堪重负的中产阶级家庭肩上的趋势，不仅会产生经济后果，还可能引发政治后果。

二、逐句翻译与核心词汇

第一段

1. During the past generation, the American middle-class family that once could count on hard work and fair play to keep itself financially secure has been transformed by economic risk and new realities.

- 翻译：在过去的一代人时间里，曾经依靠辛勤工作和公平竞争就能维持自身经济稳定的美国中产阶级家庭，已经被经济风险和新的现实彻底改变了。

- 核心词汇：

- generation n. 一代人；产生
- middle-class adj. 中产阶级的
- count on 依靠；指望
- fair play 公平竞争；公平对待
- financially secure 经济稳定的；财务安全的
- transform v. 改变；转变
- economic risk 经济风险

- 长难句分析：

- 主句：the American middle-class family has been transformed by economic risk and new realities
- 定语从句：that once could count on hard work and fair play to keep itself financially secure 修饰 family
- 时间状语：During the past generation

2. Now a pink slip, a bad diagnosis, or a disappearing spouse can reduce a family from solidly middle class to newly poor in a few months.

- 翻译：如今，一张解雇通知书、一个糟糕的诊断结果，或者配偶的离去，都能在短短几个月内让一个原本稳固的中产阶级家庭沦为新的贫困家庭。
- 核心词汇：
 - pink slip 解雇通知书
 - diagnosis n. 诊断
 - spouse n. 配偶
 - reduce...from...to... 使.....从.....沦为.....
 - solidly adv. 稳固地；牢固地

第二段

1. In just one generation, millions of mothers have gone to work, transforming basic family economics.

- 翻译：仅仅一代人的时间，数百万母亲走上了工作岗位，彻底改变了基本的家庭经济状况。
- 核心词汇：
 - transform v. 改变；转变
 - family economics 家庭经济

2. Scholars, policymakers, and critics of all stripes have debated the social implications of these changes, but few have looked at the side effect: family risk has risen as well.

- 翻译：各行各业的学者、政策制定者和评论家都在讨论这些变化带来的社会影响，但很少有人关注其副作用：家庭风险也随之上升了。
- 核心词汇：
 - scholar n. 学者
 - policymaker n. 政策制定者
 - critic n. 评论家；批评者
 - of all stripes 形形色色的；各行各业的
 - debate v./n. 辩论；讨论
 - social implication 社会影响；社会含义
 - side effect 副作用
 - rise v. 上升；增加

3. Today's families have budgeted to the limits of their new two-paycheck status.

- 翻译：如今的家庭已经把开支预算到了双薪收入的极限。
- 核心词汇：
 - budget v. 做预算；安排开支
 - to the limits of 达到.....的极限
 - two-paycheck adj. 双薪的
 - status n. 地位；状态

4. As a result, they have lost the parachute they once had in times of financial setback – a back-up earner (usually Mom) who could go into the workforce if the primary earner got laid off or fell sick.

- 翻译：结果，他们失去了曾经在经济困难时期拥有的"降落伞"——也就是那个如果主要收入者失业或生病，就可以进入职场的备用收入者（通常是母亲）。
- 核心词汇：
 - as a result 结果；因此
 - parachute n. 降落伞；应急措施
 - in times of 在.....时期

- financial setback 经济挫折; 财政困难
- back-up adj. 备用的; 后备的
- earner n. 挣钱者; 收入者
- workforce n. 劳动力; 劳动大军
- primary earner 主要收入者
- get laid off 被解雇; 下岗
- fall sick 生病
- 长难句分析:
 - 主句: they have lost the parachute
 - 定语从句1: they once had in times of financial setback 修饰 parachute
 - 同位语: a back-up earner (usually Mom) 解释说明 parachute
 - 定语从句2: who could go into the workforce if the primary earner got laid off or fell sick 修饰 back-up earner
 - 条件状语从句: if the primary earner got laid off or fell sick

5. This "added-worker effect" could support the safety net offered by unemployment insurance or disability insurance to help families weather bad times.

- 翻译: 这种"附加劳动者效应"能够补充失业保险或伤残保险所提供的社会保障网, 帮助家庭度过艰难时期。
- 核心词汇:
 - added-worker effect 附加劳动者效应
 - safety net 安全网; 社会保障体系
 - unemployment insurance 失业保险
 - disability insurance 伤残保险
 - weather v. 平安度过; 经受住
 - bad times 艰难时期; 不景气时期

6. But today, a disruption to family fortunes can no longer be made up with extra income from an otherwise-stay-at-home partner.

- 翻译: 但如今, 家庭财富遭受的损失再也无法通过原本待在家里的配偶的额外收入来弥补了。
- 核心词汇:
 - disruption n. 中断; 破坏; 损失
 - family fortune 家庭财富
 - no longer 不再
 - make up 弥补; 补偿
 - extra income 额外收入
 - otherwise adv. 原本; 否则
 - stay-at-home adj. 待在家里的; 全职的
 - partner n. 配偶; 伙伴

第三段

1. During the same period, families have been asked to absorb much more risk in their retirement income.

- 翻译: 在同一时期, 家庭还被要求承担更多的退休收入风险。
- 核心词汇:
 - absorb v. 承担; 吸收
 - retirement income 退休收入

2. **Steelworkers, airline employees, and now those in the auto industry are joining millions of families who must worry about interest rates, stock market fluctuation, and the harsh reality that they may outlive their retirement money.**

- 翻译：钢铁工人、航空公司员工，以及现在的汽车行业从业者，都加入了数百万家庭的行列，他们不得不担心利率、股市波动，以及一个残酷的现实：他们的寿命可能会超过退休金的支付年限。

- 核心词汇：

- steelworker n. 钢铁工人
- airline n. 航空公司
- auto industry 汽车行业
- interest rate 利率
- stock market fluctuation 股市波动
- harsh adj. 残酷的；严厉的
- reality n. 现实
- outlive v. 比.....活得长；比.....经久
- retirement money 退休金

- 长难句分析：

- 主句：Steelworkers, airline employees, and now those in the auto industry are joining millions of families
- 定语从句1：who must worry about interest rates, stock market fluctuation, and the harsh reality 修饰 families
- 同位语从句：that they may outlive their retirement money 解释说明 reality

3. **For much of the past year, President Bush campaigned to move Social Security to a savings-account model, with retirees trading much or all of their guaranteed payments for payments depending on investment returns.**

- 翻译：在过去一年的大部分时间里，布什总统一直致力于推动社会保障制度向储蓄账户模式转变，让退休人员将他们大部分或全部的有保障的养老金，换成取决于投资回报的收入。

- 核心词汇：

- campaign v. 发起运动；从事活动
- Social Security 社会保障（制度）
- savings-account n. 储蓄账户
- model n. 模式；模型
- retiree n. 退休人员
- trade...for... 用.....交换.....
- guaranteed adj. 有保证的；担保的
- payment n. 支付；款项
- depend on 取决于；依靠
- investment return 投资回报

- 长难句分析：

- 主句：President Bush campaigned to move Social Security to a savings-account model
- 时间状语：For much of the past year
- 伴随状语：with retirees trading much or all of their guaranteed payments for payments depending on investment returns
- 现在分词短语：depending on investment returns 作定语修饰 payments

4. **For younger families, the picture is not any better.**

- 翻译：对于年轻家庭来说，情况也好不到哪里去。
- 核心词汇：

- picture n. 情况；局面；状况

5. Both the absolute cost of healthcare and the share of it borne by families have risen – and newly fashionable health-savings plans are spreading from legislative halls to Wal-Mart workers, with much higher deductibles and a large new dose of investment risk for families' future healthcare.

- 翻译：医疗保健的绝对成本和家庭承担的份额都在上升——而且新近流行的健康储蓄计划正从立法大厅普及到沃尔玛员工，这意味着更高的免赔额，以及家庭未来医疗保健方面新增的大量投资风险。

- 核心词汇：

- absolute adj. 绝对的；完全的
 - healthcare n. 医疗保健
 - share n. 份额；部分
 - bear v. 承担；忍受（过去式：bore，过去分词：borne）
 - fashionable adj. 流行的；时髦的
 - health-savings plan 健康储蓄计划
 - spread v. 传播；普及
 - legislative hall 立法大厅；议会大厦
 - deductible n. 免赔额；自付额
 - a dose of 一剂；一份；大量
 - future adj. 未来的；将来的

- 长难句分析：

- 并列主句1: Both the absolute cost of healthcare and the share of it borne by families have risen
 - 过去分词短语: borne by families 作定语修饰 the share of it
 - 并列主句2: and newly fashionable health-savings plans are spreading from legislative halls to Wal-Mart workers
 - 伴随状语: with much higher deductibles and a large new dose of investment risk for families' future healthcare

6. Even demographics are working against the middle class family, as the odds of having a weak elderly parent – and all the attendant need for physical and financial assistance – have jumped eightfold in just one generation.

- 翻译：甚至人口统计数据也对中产阶级家庭不利，因为有一个体弱多病的年迈父母——以及随之而来的所有身体和经济援助需求——的概率，在仅仅一代人的时间里就增长了七倍。

- 核心词汇：

- demographics n. 人口统计数据；人口统计学
 - work against 对……不利；妨碍
 - odds n. 概率；可能性；几率
 - weak adj. 虚弱的；体弱的
 - elderly adj. 年老的；年长的
 - attendant adj. 随之而来的；伴随的
 - physical adj. 身体的；物理的
 - financial assistance 经济援助
 - jump v. 猛增；暴涨
 - eightfold adv./adj. 八倍地/八倍的

- 长难句分析：

- 主句: Even demographics are working against the middle class family
- 原因状语从句: as the odds of having a weak elderly parent – and all the attendant need for physical and financial assistance – have jumped eightfold in just one generation
- 插入语: – and all the attendant need for physical and financial assistance – 补充说明 having a weak elderly parent 带来的后果

第四段

1. From the middle-class family perspective, much of this, understandably, looks far less like an opportunity to exercise more financial responsibility, and a good deal more like a frightening acceleration of the wholesale shift of financial risk onto their already overburdened shoulders.

- 翻译: 可以理解, 从中产阶级家庭的角度来看, 这一切远不像是一个承担更多经济责任的机会, 而更像是一场可怕的加速, 将金融风险大规模地转移到了他们本已不堪重负的肩上。

○ 核心词汇:

- perspective n. 角度; 观点; 看法
- understandably adv. 可以理解地
- look like 看起来像
- opportunity n. 机会; 机遇
- exercise v. 行使; 履行; 运用
- financial responsibility 经济责任
- a good deal 非常; 大量
- frightening adj. 可怕的; 令人恐惧的
- acceleration n. 加速; 加速度
- wholesale adj. 大规模的; 批发的
- shift n./v. 转移; 转变
- overburdened adj. 负担过重的; 不堪重负的
- shoulder n. 肩膀; 承担

○ 长难句分析:

- 主句: much of this looks far less like an opportunity... and a good deal more like a frightening acceleration...
- 介词短语: From the middle-class family perspective 作状语
- 插入语: understandably
- 不定式短语: to exercise more financial responsibility 作定语修饰 opportunity
- 介词短语: of the wholesale shift of financial risk onto their already overburdened shoulders 作定语修饰 acceleration

2. The financial fallout has begun, and the political fallout may not be far behind.

- 翻译: 经济后果已经开始显现, 政治后果可能也不会太远了。

○ 核心词汇:

- financial adj. 金融的; 经济的
- fallout n. 后果; 余波; 影响
- political adj. 政治的
- not be far behind 不远了; 紧随其后

三、完整原文

During the past generation, the American middle-class family that once could count on hard work and fair play to keep itself financially secure has been transformed by economic risk and new realities. Now a pink slip, a bad diagnosis, or a disappearing spouse can reduce a family from solidly middle class to newly poor in a few months.

In just one generation, millions of mothers have gone to work, transforming basic family economics. Scholars, policymakers, and critics of all stripes have debated the social implications of these changes, but few have looked at the side effect: family risk has risen as well. Today's families have budgeted to the limits of their new two-paycheck status. As a result, they have lost the parachute they once had in times of financial setback – a back-up earner (usually Mom) who could go into the workforce if the primary earner got laid off or fell sick. This "added-worker effect" could support the safety net offered by unemployment insurance or disability insurance to help families weather bad times. But today, a disruption to family fortunes can no longer be made up with extra income from an otherwise-stay-at-home partner.

During the same period, families have been asked to absorb much more risk in their retirement income. Steelworkers, airline employees, and now those in the auto industry are joining millions of families who must worry about interest rates, stock market fluctuation, and the harsh reality that they may outlive their retirement money. For much of the past year, President Bush campaigned to move Social Security to a savings-account model, with retirees trading much or all of their guaranteed payments for payments depending on investment returns. For younger families, the picture is not any better. Both the absolute cost of healthcare and the share of it borne by families have risen – and newly fashionable health-savings plans are spreading from legislative halls to Wal-Mart workers, with much higher deductibles and a large new dose of investment risk for families' future healthcare. Even demographics are working against the middle class family, as the odds of having a weak elderly parent – and all the attendant need for physical and financial assistance – have jumped eightfold in just one generation.

From the middle-class family perspective, much of this, understandably, looks far less like an opportunity to exercise more financial responsibility, and a good deal more like a frightening acceleration of the wholesale shift of financial risk onto their already overburdened shoulders. The financial fallout has begun, and the political fallout may not be far behind.

四、完整翻译

在过去的一代人时间里，曾经依靠辛勤工作和公平竞争就能维持自身经济稳定的美国中产阶级家庭，已经被经济风险和新的现实彻底改变了。如今，一张解雇通知书、一个糟糕的诊断结果，或者配偶的离去，都能在短短几个月内让一个原本稳固的中产阶级家庭沦为新的贫困家庭。

仅仅一代人的时间，数百万母亲走上了工作岗位，彻底改变了基本的家庭经济状况。各行各业的学者、政策制定者和评论家都在讨论这些变化带来的社会影响，但很少有人关注其副作用：家庭风险也随之上升了。如今的家庭已经把开支预算到了双薪收入的极限。结果，他们失去了曾经在经济困难时期拥有的“降落伞”——也就是那个如果主要收入者失业或生病，就可以进入职场的备用收入者（通常是母亲）。这种“附加劳动者效应”能够补充失业保险或伤残保险所提供的社会保障网，帮助家庭度过艰难时期。但如今，家庭财富遭受的损失再也无法通过原本待在家里的配偶的额外收入来弥补了。

在同一时期，家庭还被要求承担更多的退休收入风险。钢铁工人、航空公司员工，以及现在的汽车行业从业者，都加入了数百万家庭的行列，他们不得不担心利率、股市波动，以及一个残酷的现实：他们的寿命可能会超过退休金的支付年限。在过去一年的大部分时间里，布什总统一直致力于推动社会保障制度向储蓄账户模式转变，让退休人员将他们大部分或全部的有保障的养老金，换成取决于投资回报的收入。对于年轻家庭来说，情况也好不到哪里去。医疗保健的绝对成本和家庭承担的份额都在上升——而且新近流行的健康储蓄计划正从立法大厅普及到沃尔玛员工，这意味着更高的免赔额，以及家庭未来医疗保健方面新增的大量投资风险。甚至人口统计数据也对中产阶级家庭不利，因为有一个体弱多病的年迈父母——以及随之而来的所有身体和经济援助需求——的概率，在仅仅一代人的时间里就增长了七倍。

可以理解，从中产阶级家庭的角度来看，这一切远不像是一个承担更多经济责任的机会，而更像是一场可怕的加速，将金融风险大规模地转移到了他们本已不堪重负的肩上。经济后果已经开始显现，政治后果可能也不会太远了。